HISTORY OF YOGA AND ASANAS

From ancient Indian traditions to a global practice

A short 3-minute presentation

1. What is Yoga?

The meaning and early roots

- Yoga comes from the Sanskrit root “yuj”, meaning “to join” or “to unite”.
- It developed in ancient India as a broad discipline involving meditation, self-discipline, breath, philosophy and physical practice.
- The earliest ideas connected with Yoga are found in ancient Indian traditions, including the Vedas and later Upanishads.
- Over time, Yoga developed from mainly spiritual and meditative practices into several traditions with different methods and goals.
- Today, Yoga includes both its philosophical heritage and physical practices such as asanas and pranayama.

2. History of Yoga — A Timeline

Important stages in its development

Vedic Period
(c. 1500–500 BCE)

Early Vedic traditions included ideas of ritual, concentration and disciplined living that later influenced Yoga.

Upanishadic Period
(c. 800–300 BCE)

The focus increasingly included meditation, the nature of the self, knowledge and liberation.

Classical Yoga
(c. 2nd century BCE–2nd century CE)

Patanjali's Yoga Sutras organized Yoga into an eight-limbed path, including yama, niyama, asana, pranayama and meditation.

Medieval Hatha Yoga
(c. 9th–15th centuries)

Hatha Yoga traditions expanded physical postures, breathing methods and other techniques to prepare the body and mind.

Modern Yoga
19th–20th centuries

Indian teachers helped introduce Yoga to wider audiences. Physical, health and spiritual approaches developed side by side.

3. How Asanas Became Part of Yoga

From a seated posture to many physical practices

Meaning

“Asana” is a Sanskrit term associated with a posture or seat.

Classical Yoga

In Patanjali’s system, asana is one part of the eight-limbed path and emphasizes a steady, comfortable posture.

Hatha Yoga

Medieval Hatha traditions developed a larger collection of physical postures and practices.

Modern Practice

Today, asanas are widely used for flexibility, strength, balance, mobility and mindful movement.

4. Some Well-Known Asanas

Examples commonly seen in Yoga practice

1. Tadasana — Mountain Pose

Standing posture that emphasizes stability and alignment.

2. Vrikshasana — Tree Pose

A balancing posture inspired by the steadiness of a tree.

3. Bhujangasana — Cobra Pose

A gentle back-bending posture commonly used in Yoga routines.

4. Padmasana — Lotus Pose

A traditional seated posture associated with meditation.

5. Yoga in the Modern World

How an ancient tradition became global

- During the 19th and 20th centuries, Indian teachers helped introduce Yoga to audiences outside India.
- Modern Yoga developed many styles, combining traditional ideas with physical exercise, breathing and relaxation.
- On 11 December 2014, the United Nations proclaimed 21 June as the International Day of Yoga.
- Yoga is now practiced in many countries, while its roots in Indian philosophy and traditions continue to be studied.
- Its history shows how Yoga has changed over time while remaining connected to ideas of balance, awareness and disciplined living.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Yoga is more than physical postures.

It is a long Indian tradition that has evolved across centuries, bringing together ideas of discipline, awareness, breath, meditation and movement.

THANK YOU

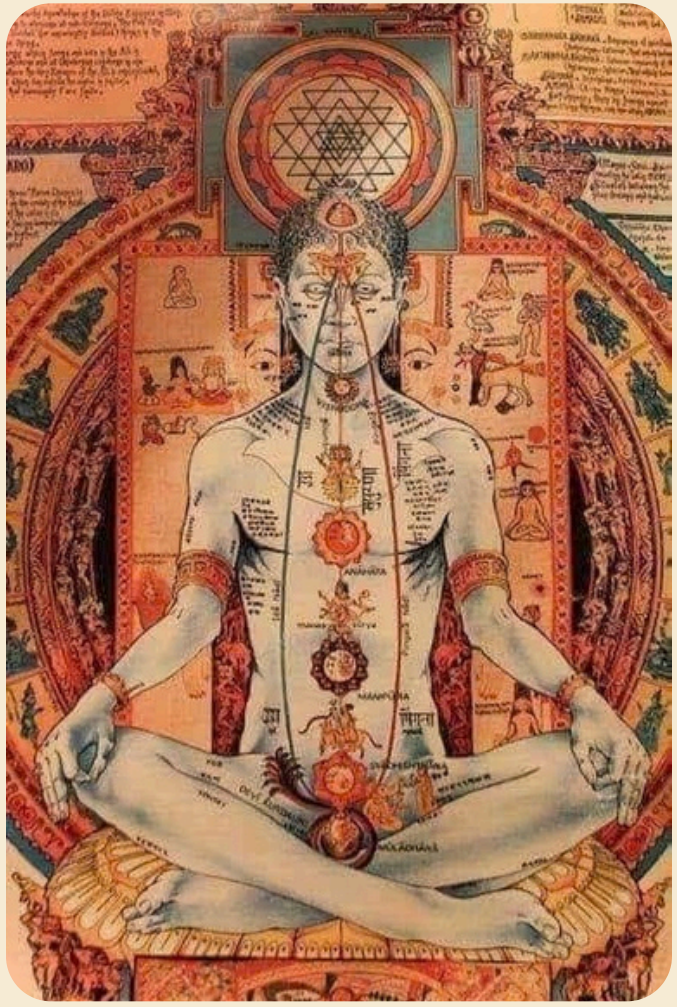
Study of Significance: Asana, Pranayama & Surya Namaskar

Indian KnowledgeSystems — GroupPresentation

Shruti Sharma • Riya Jaiswal • Sanskriti • Somya Sharma • Vaishnavi Rai



The Ancient Roots of Yoga



Vedic Period (1500–500 BCE)

Yoga concepts emerge in the Upanishads and Rigveda, shaped by early eastern Ganges basin traditions.

Meaning of the Upanishads

The Upanishads are philosophical texts at the end of the Vedas, centered on self-knowledge, meditation, and the relationship between *Atman* [individual soul/self] and *Brahman* [universal consciousness/ultimate reality].

The Four Vedas

Rigveda — The oldest, containing hymns to deities.
Yajurveda — The Veda of rituals and sacrifices.
Samaveda — The Veda of melodies and chants.
Atharvaveda — The Veda of daily procedures and spells.

Yoga Philosophy & Classical Texts

Structure of the Vedas

- Samhita — hymn collections
- Brahmana — ritual explanations
- Aranyaka — forest texts for meditation and symbolic interpretation
- Upanishad — Inner spiritual wisdom.



Patanjali's Yoga Sutras (c. 400 CE)

Codifies yoga as the "stilling of the fluctuations of the mind" — the foundational philosophical framework for all yogic practice.

Hatha Yoga Pradipika (15th Century)

Systematizes asanas and pranayama practices into a cohesive physical and energetic discipline accessible to practitioners of all levels.

The Eight Limbs of Yoga (Ashtanga)

Patanjali's **Ashtanga framework** situates physical and breath practice within a complete path toward liberation.

01

1. Yama

Ethical principles — how we relate to others.

02

2. Niyama

Personal discipline — habits for inner growth.

03

3. Asana

Physical postures — preparing the body for stillness.

04

4. Pranayama

Breath control — directing and expanding life-energy.

05

5. Pratyahara

Sense withdrawal — turning attention inward.

06

6. Dharana

Concentration — sustained focus on one point.

07

7. Dhyana

Meditation — uninterrupted contemplation.

08

8. Samadhi

Liberation/enlightenment — complete absorption and freedom.



CHAPTER 1

ASANA

TheFoundation of Physical Practice

What is Asana?



> "A position that is steady and comfortable — one's ability to sit for extended periods."
> — **Patanjali, Yoga Sutras**

- **Word Origin:** Sanskrit root *"āsa"* means "to sit down" — asana refers to any yoga posture or pose
- **Classical Definition:** An immobile bodily posture that isolates the mind by freeing it from attention to bodily functions
- **Purpose:** Prepare body and mind for meditation and deeper spiritual practice



Benefits & Major Categories of Asana

💪 Physical

Builds strength, flexibility, and improves body chemistry

🧠 Mental

Sharpens focus, reduces stress, and steadies the mind

🕉️ Spiritual

Prepares the practitioner for deeper meditation and self-realization

Major Asana Categories

- **Standing Poses:** Tadasana, Uttanasana, Virabhadrasana (Warrior poses)
- **Seated Poses:** Padmasana (Lotus), Sukhasana (Easy pose)
- **Backbends:** Bhujangasana (Cobra), Urdhva Mukha Svanasana (Upward Dog)
- **Forward Bends & Twists:** Paschimottanasana, Ardha Matsyendrasana



CHAPTER 2

PRANAYAMA

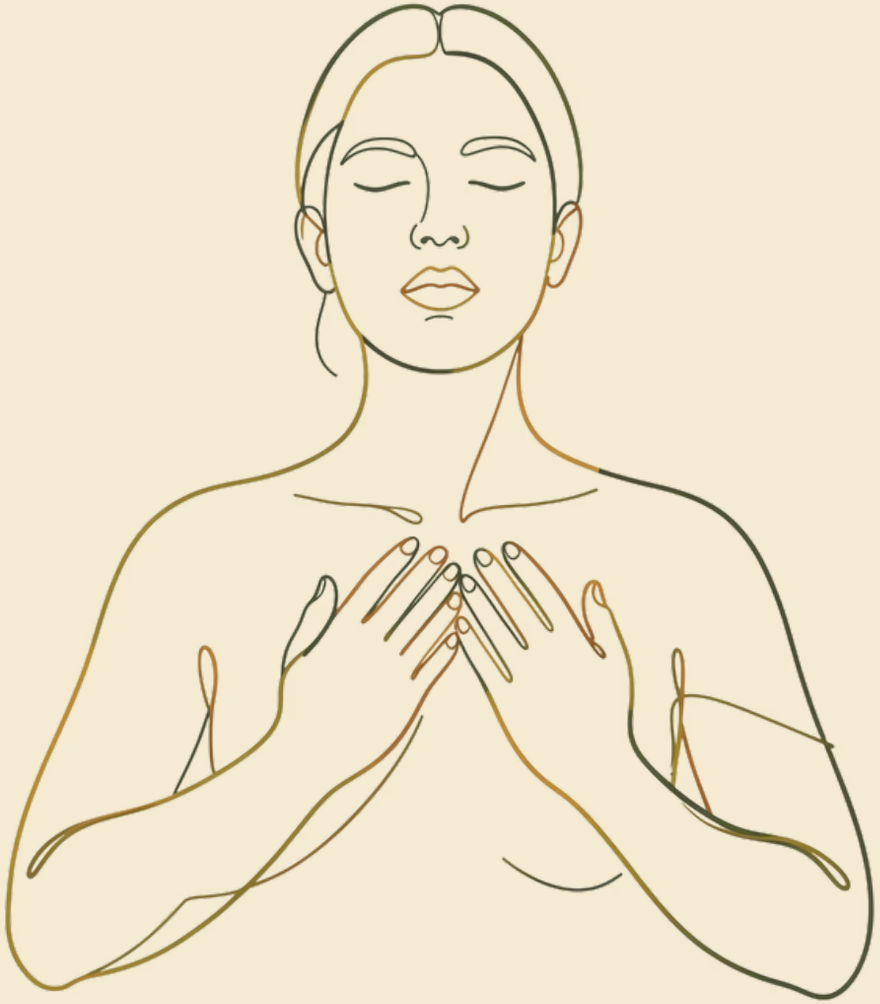
Mastering the Life-Force

What is Pranayama?

Prana = Breath and life energy
This is the energy that keeps us alive and helps the body and mind work together.

Ayama = To guide and control
This means using the breath in a steady, intentional way to help calm and focus the body and mind.

> "Still the breath, and the mind grows still."
> — **Hatha Yoga Pradipika**



Key Pranayama Techniques



Nadi Shodhana [Nadi = energy channel, Shodhana = purification]

Alternate-nostril breathing — balances the left and right energy channels, promoting calm and equilibrium



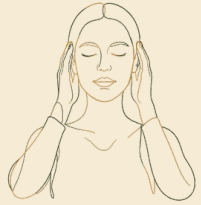
Kapalabhati [Kapala = skull, Bhati = shining/light]

Skull-shining breath — rapid exhalations that cleanse the respiratory system and energize the mind



Bhastrika [Bhastrika = bellows]

Bellows breath — builds internal heat, boosts vitality, and activates the nervous system



Ujjayi [Ujjayi = victorious/ocean sound] & Bhramari [Bhramari = bee]

Ocean breath and **humming-bee breath** — cultivate calm focus and soothe the nervous system

CHAPTER 3

SURYA NAMASKAR

Salutation to the Sun



What is Surya Namaskar?

Surya Namaskar is a simple yoga routine that combines movement, breathing, and focus.

- **The Sun Salutation**

  A set of 12 yoga poses done in order. It is a way to show respect to the sun.

- **Dynamic Structure**

  The poses flow one after another. You match each movement with a breath.

- **Traditional Timing**

  It is often done in the morning, facing the rising sun. This helps wake up the body and mind.



Surya Namaskar, Integration & Key Takeaways

Surya Namaskar — Salutation to the Sun

Surya Namaskar is a set of 12 yoga poses. It is usually done in the morning.

- Moves the whole body
- Matches movement with breathing
- Often done facing the rising sun

The Holistic Integration

01

Asana

Body poses that help you stretch and stay strong.

02

Pranayama

Breathing practice that helps you stay calm and focused.

03

Surya Namaskar

A full morning practice that connects movement and breath.

These three ideas work together to support a healthy daily routine.

The 12 Steps of Surya Namaskar

Thisdynamicsequenceofpostures,synchronizedwiththebreath,harmonizesbody,mind, and spirit, preparing the practitioner for the day.

1. Pranamasana

Prayer Pose: Stand tall, palms at heart center.

2. Hasta Uttanasana

Raised Arms Pose: Inhale, sweep arms up and back.

3. Hasta Padasana

Hand to Foot Pose: Exhale, fold forward, hands to floor.

4. Ashwa Sanchalanasana

Equestrian Pose: Inhale, step right foot back, knee down, look up.

5. Dandasana

Plank Pose: Exhale, step left foot back, body in a straight line.

6. Ashtanga Namaskara

Eight-Limbed Salutation: Knees, chest, chin to floor.

7. Bhujangasana

Cobra Pose: Inhale, lift chest, shoulders back.

8. Parvatasana

Mountain Pose: Exhale, hips up, Downward-Facing Dog.

9. Ashwa Sanchalanasana

Equestrian Pose: Inhale, step right foot forward, look up.

10. Hasta Padasana

Hand to Foot Pose: Exhale, step left foot forward, fold.

11. Hasta Uttanasana

Raised Arms Pose: Inhale, sweep arms up and back.

12. Tadasana

Mountain Pose: Exhale, return to standing, palms at heart.

Benefits of Surya Namaskar

Surya Namaskar offers a comprehensive array of advantages, harmonizing physical vitality, mental clarity, and spiritual well-being through its dynamic sequence.

Physical Fortification

Strengthens major muscle groups, enhances flexibility and balance, improves cardiovascular health, and aids in body toning.

Physiological Harmony

Stimulates endocrine glands, regulates blood pressure, boosts circulation, strengthens the respiratory system, and supports detoxification.

Mental Acuity

Reduces stress and anxiety, sharpens focus and concentration, calms the mind, and promotes overall mental clarity.

Spiritual Awakening

Deepens the connection between body, mind, and spirit, fosters self-awareness, channels positive energy, and cultivates inner peace.

Summary & Key Takeaways

Asana: Physical Foundation

Cultivates physical strength, flexibility, and mental steadiness, forming the essential base for deeper yogic practices.

Pranayama: Vital Energy Control

Directs and expands life-force (Prana) through controlled breathing, purifying the body and calming the mind.

Surya Namaskar: Unified Practice

A dynamic sequence harmonizing movement, breath, and meditation, awakening vitality and promoting holistic well-being.

Integration: Holistic Path

Together, these practices offer a comprehensive framework from ancient Indian knowledge for cultivating mind-body-spirit harmony and self-realization.



Resources for Further Learning

Deepen your understanding and practice of yoga through these valuable resources.



Classical Texts

Explore foundational scriptures like Patanjali's *Yoga Sutras* and the *Hatha Yoga Pradipika* for original philosophical and practical insights.



Online Resources

Utilize reputable yoga websites, apps, and online courses for guided practices, tutorials, and comprehensive articles on yoga's many facets.



Government Initiatives

Learn about programs and events, including International Yoga Day, promoted by the Indian government to spread awareness and education globally.



Practice Tips

Prioritize consistency, find a qualified teacher, and listen to your body to cultivate a safe, sustainable, and evolving personal yoga practice.

Thank You

Shruti Sharma, Riya Jaiswal, Sanskriti, Somya Sharma, Vaishnavi Rai

Any Questions?